

# The Lighthouse at the End of the Road

Nobody in Bellweather remembered when the old lighthouse had last been lit. It stood on a black cliff beyond the northern edge of town, where the paved road narrowed to gravel before disappearing beneath weeds. Decades of salt and wind had stripped most of the white paint from its walls.

Everyone agreed that the lighthouse was abandoned.

One October evening, twelve-year-old Mara Vale was riding her bicycle home when she saw a flash above the trees.

She stopped.

Ten seconds later, it flashed again.

Mara had passed the old road hundreds of times, but she had never followed it. Her father had warned her that the cliffs were unstable and the lighthouse wasn't safe.

Another flash appeared.

Curiosity won.

Mara left her bicycle beside a fallen road sign and walked toward the lighthouse. The front door was unlocked.

"Hello?"

No answer.

Inside, a spiral staircase disappeared into darkness. Mara pulled a flashlight from her backpack and climbed.

The lantern room at the top was empty. There was no electricity and no working lamp. The enormous glass lens hadn't moved in years.

But something on the floor was ticking.

A brass pocket watch.

Mara picked it up. It showed 6:17.

Her own watch showed 6:12.

Five minutes ahead.

She turned the brass watch over.

Someone had engraved three words into the back.

**FOR MARA VALE.**

Suddenly, the lighthouse door slammed shut below her.

Mara hurried downstairs, but the door refused to open.

Then she heard three knocks.

They came from behind her.

A narrow wooden door stood beneath the staircase. Mara was certain she hadn't noticed it when she entered.

She opened it.

A second staircase descended underground.

At the bottom was a circular room filled with hundreds of moving brass gears. Some were smaller than coins. Others stretched from floor to ceiling. Their constant ticking sounded like hundreds of clocks running at once.

An old man sat behind a wooden desk.

"You took your time," he said.

"Who are you?"

"Edwin."

Mara held up the pocket watch. "Did you make this?"

Edwin glanced at it.

"You've got four minutes."

"Until what?"

"The Bellweather Bridge collapses."

Mara froze.

Her father crossed that bridge every evening on his way home from work.

She pulled out her phone. No signal.

"I need to warn him."

"That's why you're here."

Mara looked at the gears surrounding them.

"What is this place?"

"This lighthouse doesn't guide ships anymore," Edwin said. "It guides moments. Occasionally, it lets us see five minutes farther down the road than everyone else."

Mara looked at the pocket watch.

6:13.

"Then stop the bridge from collapsing!"

"I can't."

"Why not?"

"Seeing the future isn't the same as controlling it."

"Then why show me?"

Edwin smiled.

"Because sometimes five minutes is enough."

Mara ran.

She climbed the stairs two at a time, burst through the lighthouse door, and grabbed her bicycle.

6:14.

She pedaled harder than she ever had before.

Her phone still had no signal.

6:15.

The highway appeared through the trees. Beyond it stood the Bellweather Bridge, carrying a steady line of cars across the river.

Then Mara saw a familiar blue truck approaching the bridge.

Her father's.

Her phone suddenly showed one bar.

She called.

He answered.

"Hey, kiddo."

"Dad, stop the car!"

"What?"

"Don't go on the bridge!"

"Mara, what's going on?"

6:16.

"Dad, please!"

The truck's brake lights appeared.

Her father stopped just before the entrance. Cars behind him honked.

Then the pocket watch clicked.

6:17.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the center of the bridge dropped.

Steel twisted. Concrete cracked apart and crashed into the river below.

Mara stared in horror.

Her father's truck sat only yards from the broken edge.

That night, after police cars and fire engines filled the highway, Mara returned to the lighthouse.

She needed answers.

But the door was locked.

She walked around the building and looked through a dusty window.

There was no spiral staircase.

No enormous lens.

No underground doorway.

The lighthouse was completely empty.

Mara reached into her pocket.

The brass watch was still there.

She turned it over.

The engraving had changed.

**FOR MARA VALE, KEEPER OF FIVE MINUTES.**

The second hand began moving.

Tick.

Tick.

Tick.

Mara looked toward Bellweather, where hundreds of lights glowed beneath the dark sky.

Then she looked at the watch.

It was five minutes fast again.

Somewhere in town, something else was about to happen.